

Foot Care Help in Alberta for a Low-Income Adult

Every funding route we could find — with who qualifies, what's covered, and who to call

Prepared July 2026 • Focus: adult on AISH/ADAP with chronic lymphedema

Start here: the doors that are actually open

You hit walls at AADL and AISH because you were asking for “podiatry,” and podiatry is the one foot-care route Alberta deliberately caps. But medically necessary foot care is not a closed door — it just wears different labels. Three of them are wide open:

1. **A family doctor (MD) treating his feet is 100% covered, with no cap.** AHCIP fully insures medically necessary physician services. The \$250 limit applies ONLY to a podiatrist — not to a doctor. The same foot problem, seen by an MD, costs nothing.
2. **Home Care nursing foot care is free, and you can self-refer by calling 811.** If he can't safely care for his own feet (true for lymphedema), AHS Home Care can put nursing foot care in his care plan at no cost. No doctor referral needed — anyone can call on his behalf.
3. **For orthotics, footwear and compression, the money is in AADL and AISH — under other section names.** Foot orthotics/arch supports run through AISH personal benefits; therapeutic/custom footwear and braces run through AADL Sections FT/F/OP; compression garments through AADL Sections N/T. As an AISH recipient he pays no AADL cost-share.

Bottom line: foot care as a medical need has open, free routes. “Podiatry” as a billing category is the narrow one. Aim at the medical-need doors.

The fastest path for Xavier (recommended order)

4. **Call Health Link 811** and ask for a Continuing Care / Home Care assessment for nursing foot care — free, self-referral, best fit for lymphedema. (You can call for him.)
5. **Book his family doctor** for the foot issues themselves (fully insured), and ask the doctor to refer him to his zone's lymphedema clinic and, if there's any ulcer/infection risk, a wound clinic or limb-preservation centre.
6. **Call Alberta Supports 1-877-644-9992** to (a) start AADL for compression garments and any therapeutic footwear, and (b) ask his AISH worker about a health-related personal benefit for foot orthotics/arch supports. Keep all receipts.
7. **Use 211 (dial 2-1-1)** to find the nearest free/low-cost community foot clinic in your town.

At-a-glance: which door for what

What he needs	Best program	How to start
Treatment of the foot problem (skin, infection, wounds)	Family doctor (AHCIP) — fully covered, no cap	Book a regular doctor visit
Routine nail/foot care he can't safely do himself	AHS Home Care nursing foot care — free	Call 811, ask for assessment

High-risk / ulcerated / infected feet	AHS wound clinic, High-Risk Foot Team, Zivot (Calgary)	Doctor referral
Foot orthotics / arch supports	AISH health-related personal benefit	AISH worker / 1-877-644-9992
Therapeutic or custom footwear, braces/AFOs	AADL Sections FT / F / OP	AADL authorizer assessment
Compression garments (lymphedema)	AADL Sections N / T (no cost-share on AISH)	AADL / lymphedema clinic
If First Nations/Inuit or a veteran	NIHB or Veterans Affairs	See section below

Detail, eligibility, catches and phone numbers for each of these follow below.

1. Publicly insured medical foot care (no cap)

Family doctor / specialist

- **What** — Any medically necessary assessment or treatment of the feet by a physician (MD) is fully insured by AHCIP. There is no dollar cap — the \$250 cap is specific to podiatrists.
- **Who qualifies** — Anyone with a valid Alberta Health Care card.
- **Catch** — A doctor isn't a nail-care technician; this covers medical treatment (infections, wounds, skin breakdown, structural problems), not routine cosmetic nail trimming — for that, see Home Care below.

Source: [AHCIP — what is covered](#)

Podiatric surgery in an AHS facility

- **What** — Surgery by a podiatric surgeon in an Alberta hospital or AHS-contracted facility is fully covered — not subject to the \$250 cap.
- **How** — Requires a physician referral.

Source: [Schedule of Podiatric Surgery Benefits](#)

2. Free AHS clinical foot-care pathways

Home Care nursing foot care — the best free route

- **What** — Under Continuing Care, nursing foot care can be part of a care plan when someone can't safely manage their own feet — a strong fit for lymphedema/elephantiasis (impaired reach, fragile skin, infection risk).
- **Who qualifies** — Any Albertan with a valid health card; eligibility is by an assessment of unmet care need, not a diagnosis list or income test.
- **Cost** — Professional/personal care services are provided at no cost. Some supplies, homemaking, or day-program services may carry a fee, and this can vary by zone — confirm locally.
- **How to start** — **Call Health Link 811** and request a Home Care / Continuing Care assessment. No referral needed — you can call for him.

Sources: [How to access continuing care](#) • [Continuing Care Access contacts](#)

AHS wound care clinics

- **What** — Specialty clinics for complex/chronic wounds — directly relevant since lymphedema causes ulceration and cellulitis. Includes footwear/gait assessment and AADL shoe/compression referrals; some sites offer drop-in wound care for marginalized clients.
- **Cost / catch** — Publicly funded, but the client pays for dressing supplies, the 25% AADL cost-share on shoes/hosiery (waived for AISH), and parking.
- **How** — Accessed through Community Care Access / Home Care; you must have a family doctor or nurse practitioner on file.

Source: [Example: Sheldon M. Chumir Wound Clinic](#)

High-Risk Foot Teams & Diabetes Foot Care Pathway

- **What** — Multidisciplinary teams (nursing, PT, OT, orthotist, physicians) for feet at risk of, or with, ulcers.
- **Catch** — Built around diabetes/wounds. A lymphedema patient with an active or high-risk ulcer may be accepted on a wound basis, but non-diabetic lymphedema isn't explicitly listed — confirm with the team.
- **How** — Provider referral via the Alberta Referral Directory.

Source: [AHS Diabetes Foot Care Pathway](#)

Zivot Limb Preservation Centre (Calgary)

- **What** — Peter Lougheed Centre program for high-risk feet — ulcers, infections, chronic wounds, Charcot foot — and limb-salvage surgery. The most plausible AHS home for advanced lymphedema-related foot complications.
- **How** — Physician or NP referral required. Publicly funded.

Source: [Zivot Limb Preservation Centre](#)

Lymphedema clinics (publicly funded)

These treat the lymphedema itself (compression, bandaging, garment fitting, skin-care education) and authorize AADL garments. They don't do routine nail care but are the natural referral hub.

- **Calgary — CALS** — Calgary Ambulatory Lymphedema Service, Sheldon M. Chumir. Ages 16+, non-cancer lymphedema, Calgary Zone. Phone **403-955-6052**. Cancer-related lymphedema → Rehab Oncology **403-476-2910**.
- **Edmonton — CRIS** — Community Rehabilitation Interdisciplinary Service, non-cancer lymphedema. Phone **780-735-2413**.
- **Access** — Provider referral via the Alberta Referral Directory; residency limits apply by zone.

Sources: [CALS \(Calgary\)](#) • [CRIS \(Edmonton\)](#)

3. What AHCIP podiatry actually covers (and its limits)

- **The cap** — Basic podiatry is partially covered up to \$250 per benefit year (July 1 – June 30). Podiatrists may charge additional fees above that.
- **Billing** — The podiatrist bills AHCIP for the covered portion; the patient pays the rest. He just shows his Alberta Health Care card.

- **No reimbursement form** — There is no self-serve online form to claim podiatry back from AHCIP within Alberta. (The only AHCIP claim forms are for insured services received outside Alberta — and podiatry outside Alberta isn't covered at all.)
- **Verify** — Exact covered services/amounts: AHCIP **1-780-427-1432** or Health Link **811**.

Sources: [AHCIP — what is covered](#) • [AHCIP — submit a claim](#)

4. Benefit programs for orthotics, footwear & supplies

AISH health-related personal benefit — foot orthotics & arch supports

- **Covers (listed by name)** — Arch supports or foot orthotics; splints and braces; and health services such as physiotherapy, chiropractic, massage and acupuncture.
- **How to request** — Through his **AISH worker** (there's no self-serve online portal). Call Alberta Supports **1-877-644-9992**.
- **Catches** — Must have ≤ \$5,000 in non-exempt assets (or be in hardship), demonstrate need, and the item must not be available through another source (e.g., AADL). Some personal benefits must be repaid.

Source: [What you get with AISH](#)

AADL — therapeutic footwear, custom footwear, orthotics/braces

- **Section FT (Therapeutic Footwear)** — Therapeutic shoes, total-contact inserts, pressure-downloading orthoses, shoe modifications. Aimed at the high-risk foot (neuropathy, ischemia, ulcer history). Lymphedema alone may not meet the criteria unless it produces a qualifying condition — needs a high-risk-foot-team assessment.
- **Section F (Custom-Made Footwear)** — Fully custom-manufactured footwear for those who need it; requires a certified pedorthist/craftsman assessment.
- **Section OP (Orthotic & Prosthetic)** — Braces/AFOs for an ongoing chronic condition (one primary device per limb).
- **Cost-share exemption** — AADL normally charges 25% up to \$500/family per year — but AISH recipients are exempt and pay nothing. Confirm his exemption with AADL.
- **How** — A clinical assessment by an AADL-approved authorizer is required. AADL info via Alberta Supports **1-877-644-9992** or AADL **780-427-0731**.

Sources: [AADL cost-sharing](#) • [Cost-share exemption form \(AADL1859\)](#)

AADL — compression garments (lymphedema)

- **What** — Section N (ready-made) and Section T (custom) fund compression garments for chronic lymphedema. Requires an assessment by a Certified Lymphedema Therapist or authorizer (or a physician prescription). No cost-share for AISH recipients.

Sources: [AADL Section N](#) • [AADL Section T](#)

What does NOT cover foot care (so you don't waste time)

- **Alberta Adult Health Benefit & Alberta Child Health Benefit** — cover drugs, dental, optical, diabetes supplies and ambulance only. No podiatry, orthotics or footwear. (Also, an adult on AISH can't be on AAHB at the same time.)
- **Health Benefit Exception process (form AEHB3487)** — reviews only drugs, optical, dental, ambulance and diabetes supplies. Foot-care items are out of scope.

Source: [Alberta Adult Health Benefit](#)

5. Federal & status-based coverage

Non-Insured Health Benefits (NIHB) — First Nations / Inuit

- **Covers** — Orthopedic/custom footwear, foot orthotics, and orthotics/braces (prior approval for custom items). Enrolled providers bill NIHB directly, so eligible items cost the client \$0.
- **How** — Get a prescription/assessment; use an NIHB-enrolled supplier. Info via Express Scripts Canada **1-855-618-6291**.

Source: [NIHB overview](#)

Veterans Affairs Canada

- **Covers** — Foot care services, orthopedic footwear/modifications and orthotics for eligible veterans, with preauthorization and a recognized prescriber.
- **How** — Contact VAC **1-866-522-2122**.

Source: [VAC footwear/orthotics policy](#)

6. Charities & low-cost community clinics

- **211 Alberta (dial 2-1-1)** — The live directory for free/low-cost foot clinics near any town — the best tool for local church/Lions/nurse sliding-scale services, which change often.
- **CUPS (Calgary)** — Low-barrier walk-in Access Care Clinic for people meeting the low-income cut-off with no family doctor; nursing and wound care, and help completing AISH/DTC forms. Nurse line **403-389-2712**.
- **Radius Community Health (Edmonton)** — Formerly Boyle McCauley Health Centre — runs a dedicated foot-care clinic for vulnerable Edmontonians; “turns nobody away,” subject to intake.
- **The Alex (Calgary)** — Community and Seniors Health Centres run foot clinics for low-income/inner-city clients (Seniors centre serves low-income Calgarians 60+ without a doctor).
- **Primary Care Network (PCN) foot-care programs** — Many PCNs run free foot-care-nurse programs (often diabetic/at-risk) for patients rostered to their clinics. Ask whether his family doctor’s clinic belongs to a PCN with a foot-care nurse.
- **Seniors (65+) — partial help** — Alberta seniors may access help toward in-home nursing foot care via the Alberta Blue Cross Seniors benefit / Special Needs Assistance. Amounts vary — confirm with Alberta Blue Cross. (Only relevant if/when he’s 65+.)
- **Training / student foot-care clinics** — Some Alberta foot-care-nurse academies run supervised practice clinics with reduced fees — call to ask about public clinic days (e.g., NorQuest College; Alberta Foot Care Academy; Nursing Soles; Edmonton Foot Care Academy).

Sources: [211 Alberta](#) • [CUPS Health Clinic](#) • [Radius Community Health](#)

7. Tax measures (only if there’s income to offset)

- **Medical Expense Tax Credit (METC)** — Custom foot orthotics, custom orthopedic footwear, prescribed compression garments, and podiatrist/chiropract fees are eligible — the out-of-pocket portion only.

- **Disability Tax Credit (DTC)** — For a severe, prolonged impairment (Form T2201). Doesn't pay for foot care directly but unlocks other benefits.
- **The catch** — Both are non-refundable — they only reduce tax owing. With little or no taxable income they return nothing, unless the credit is transferred to a supporting family member who has income (which may apply here, given the caregiver relationship). Worth keeping receipts regardless.

Source: [CRA — eligible medical expenses](#)

Worth confirming by phone

- Whether Home Care in his zone includes routine foot care at no cost, or attaches a supply fee (varies by zone) — Health Link 811.
- Whether the High-Risk Foot Team / Zivot / diabetes pathway will take non-diabetic lymphedema — ask the specific team.
- Whether his feet meet AADL Section FT therapeutic-footwear criteria — needs a high-risk-foot assessment.
- His AISH cost-share exemption status for AADL, and the exact personal-benefit process — his AISH worker.
- Current seniors' foot-care amounts (if/when 65+) — Alberta Blue Cross.

Key phone numbers

Service	Number
Alberta Supports (AISH, AADL, benefits)	1-877-644-9992
Health Link (Home Care self-referral, nurse advice)	811
AHCIP (coverage questions)	1-780-427-1432
AADL program	780-427-0731
211 Alberta (local free/low-cost clinics)	Dial 2-1-1
CALS lymphedema clinic (Calgary)	403-955-6052
CRIS lymphedema clinic (Edmonton)	780-735-2413
NIHB / Express Scripts (First Nations, Inuit)	1-855-618-6291
Veterans Affairs Canada	1-866-522-2122

This guide summarizes public Government of Alberta, AHS, federal and non-profit sources current as of July 2026. Programs, amounts and clinic eligibility change — confirm the details that matter by phone before relying on them.